Erick

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The Night Before

AGD-01

After the Good Dream

The Night Before

Do not love half lovers
Do not entertain half friends
Do not indulge in works of the half talented
Do not live half a life and do not die a half death

— Kahlil Gibran, "Half is not Enough"

The "Great" Storyteller: You've certainly heard your fair share of stories. From the bedtime tales your mom told you to the bragging from kids at school...

The "Great" Storyteller: Or, or... like those smooth talkers you occasionally encounter in taverns.

The "Great" Storyteller: Stories in the classroom, on benches where pigeons are fed, on TV and in comic books... you've heard plenty, and most of them are cliché.

The "Great" Storyteller: But hear me out, I'm sure you've never heard a story as astonishing and legendary as this one!

The "Great" Storyteller: It's more thrilling than the surging waves of the sea—a story that a bard could captivate a tavern full of drunks with, every one of them forgetting their drinks.

The "Great" Storyteller: And you. You will be honored as its very first listener!

The room is silent, the chaos outside blocked by the suitcase. Not even a thousand woodpeckers could peck open this door—

"Bang—!"

The door bursts open.

Sonetto: Timekeeper, now's the time, put the arm ring on her!

Sonetto pins the girl to the ground and winds back her head, preparing to deliver a dizzying headbutt.

???: You bunch of sneak-attacking thieves! Harald will come looking, and then he'll throw you all... into the sea to feed the fish!

Vertin: ...

???: What—what are you doing!?

Vertin: Erick, we need you to calm down.

The arm ring settles in its familiar resting place, grasping her slender yet firm arm.

They bind her with rope and place her in a chair.

Erick: Let—me go!

Erick: You damn kidnappers, eat my foot!

The girl's feet, unable to touch the ground, jab wildly at her two captors.

But like a puppy on a leash, her target is just out of reach.

Sonetto: Sorry, it was my miscalculation... I thought a 12-year-old Arcanist would be gentler and more... controllable.

Vertin: No one could have anticipated this.

Sonetto: Yes. Next time, I'll consider using Arcane Skills.

The "Great" Storyteller: At this moment, our protagonist, a brave and clever captive, watches quietly. She narrows her eyes, trying to determine the origin of her two assailants.

Erick: Huh? Ah, I've seen that emblem before. So you're from that What's-it-called Foundation!

Sonetto: You know about us!

Erick: Hmph, of course. I have eyes and ears everywhere.

Erick: Anyway, neither of you will pry a word out of me! Even if you pull out my teeth one by one without any anesthetic, it's impossible!

Erick proudly raises her head, as if her hands are akimbo on her hips rather than bound behind her back.

Sonetto: I've seen your family's records. Your mother's side has lived in Sogn Fjord for generations.

Sonetto: She's an extraordinary woman. The Norwegian branch of the St. Pavlov Foundation has received a lot of help from her.

Sonetto: But ever since she...

Erick: Quite well-informed, aren't you, long-ears?

Erick: If she hadn't sailed off for that incredible treasure, you would never have caught me!

Vertin: Sonetto...

Vertin gives a subtle shake of the head.

Sonetto: ...I understand.

Sonetto: Anyway, you're living with your grandfather and father now, right?

Vertin: We mean you no harm. Just, considering your father's and grandfather's status as Arcanists, we would like to offer you as much help as possible.

Sonetto: We have a unique school filled with kids like you—extraordinary ones. I think you'd be interested.

Erick: But I'm already in school—I mean, I already have a school within my territory!

Erick: I have a crew of sailors there, ready to plunder everything here at my signal!

Vertin: But our school is unique. It's full of territories yet unclaimed.

Sonetto: Yes, and a bunch of kids—sailors—yearning for a jarl to lead them.

Erick: Oh... that does sound tempting. More interesting than the tedium of Stillwater Lake School anyway...

Erick: But I need to speak to my crew. Not for their approval, of course! Just so they don't panic without me.

Erick: You know, they're lost without someone at the helm—

Vertin: We've already gotten Harald's consent, Erick.

Erick: But...

A small wooden scabbard lies on the table, along with a letter.

Vertin: This is what he left for you.

Erick, her hands freed, picks up the letter from the table.

Letter: "Erick, you're about to venture into a place full of dangers. It will be daunting and fearsome."

Letter: “Every warrior of Valhalla must face such a challenge before adulthood; you will endure many hardships and a long, long time without us.”

Letter: “But I believe you'll make new friendships and return triumphant with countless treasures.”

Letter: “When the time comes, your father and I will throw a night-long feast for you, with unlimited soda and popcorn of every flavor.”

Letter: “Note: You can trust these two; they're good people.”

Letter: “––Yours forever, Harald.”

Erick: Oh... okay, I thought I'd get a proper chance to say goodbye to everyone.

Erick: Jason “the Slob's” workbook is still at my place, and there are two raid allowances I haven’t used this month...

She sulks, cupping her cheeks, elbows on the table, her face puffed up like a blowfish.

TO BE CONTINUED...

Pointy Stick and Wooden Sword

AGD-02

Pointy Stick and Wooden Sword

One month later

School of Primary Defense of Mankind

Students swarm to the end of the hallway, gazing up at the little jarl on the stairs.

Student I: Hey, don't push me!

Student II: Who stepped on my shoe!?

Student III: Shh, shush! Quiet down!

Erick: ...In any case, as your jarl, I promise you fame, fortune, and... extra snacks!

Erick: Row those oars like never before, sailors! Just like the mysterious adventurers of old!

The crowd cheers in unison.

Golden Key Sancho: You’re going to get caught by the instructors... then you’ll be locked in a dark room all day without any food. Breaking school rules is such a dumb idea.

His sharp voice pierces the excited atmosphere.

The excitement dissipates, and the little ones in robes start whispering, their eyes all focused on him.

Golden Key Sancho: This is so unrealistic. I suggest you spend more time preparing for the next test. The students who score lowest will have to take extra classes to make up for it.

Golden Key Sancho: Most importantly, if you do poorly in Arcane Skills, you'll probably end up as janitors after graduation.

Golden Key Sancho: Sitting in a lonely office with a musty smell you can’t get rid of...

Children's minds are always so vividly imaginative.

Golden Key Sancho: Hmph, and I'll become the brightest star at the LSCC.

Golden Key Sancho: You'd better start thinking more practically, like me...

Erick: Are you kidding!? I've known many cowards like you before...

Golden Key Sancho: Hmph, who's the coward? At least I don't need others to do my bidding.

Erick: You...!

Erick's face turns red with anger.
Just as she's about to storm over—

A hand grabs her.

Effie: For the peace and welfare of mankind! What you're doing is completely pointless.

Like weather vanes, the crowd turn their heads to this new interloper.

Student I: It's Dreary Eifer! Run!

Student II: Ugh, she's going to put me off my lunch...

The little robes scatter, leaving the three of them standing alone.

Erick: Hey, don't go! Our plan isn't even—

Effie: Your plan is meaningless, regardless of whether you fail or succeed. In the end, you'll either face endless anxiety or insatiable emptiness.

The girl with the dim eyes points at the retreating crowd.

Effie: Even if you assemble them time and again, they'll still walk away in the end.

Golden Key Sancho: Not true! Some people are meant for more! And the others...

Erick: Agh... so annoying! Both of you, just shut up!

She storms over, kicking up a cloud of dust with each step.

A battle for glory is inevitable.

The three scuffle, pushing and shoving, but none yields to the others.

The school bell rings. They freeze momentarily. Then, they scatter like kittens and race back to the classroom.

Instructor: ...As for the glavakus, they are a kind of critter that primarily inhabits the tropical rainforests of North America.

Instructor: Being omnivorous, they are an adaptable species with a remarkable ability to form colonies even in the most extreme conditions.

Instructor: Please turn to page 126 of "The Compendium of Critters."

Instructor: As you can see, studies show that their colonies operate under a distinct hierarchy.

Instructor: The stronger the scent of a glavakus, the higher its status. They rely on their acute sense of smell and sensitive hearing, for they lack vision.

Instructor: From our last class, how should you react when encountering such creatures?

Students: Do not run or jump; walk quietly!

During the students' unified chant, a slight discord can be heard.

Erick: Pfft, pfft...

Golden Key Sancho & Effie: ?

Erick: You two... have truly impressed me. I challenge you to a duel!

Erick: The loser will bow to the winner and become their faithful sailor!

Erick's assertive voice pierces the chorus, and the instructor frowns.

Instructor: Erick, you seem to have some... unique opinions.

Instructor: Stand up and share them.

Erick: W-What?

She stands up hastily. The blackboard reads, “Large, Dangerous Critters.”

Erick: Um…

Clearly, our hero's attention was never on the instructor.
Scratching her cheek, she tries to recall any relevant information.

Erick: Well, my grandfather Harald once said…

She looks up at the frowning instructor. The classroom falls silent. All eyes are on her.

Erick: He said, “In life, one must defeat many things, like super-heavy cars or giant brown bears. But the most dangerous of all…

Erick: “Is the endless Vanity and boundless Emptiness.”

The instructor's eyes flicker with confusion, but she listens intently.

Erick: The monster known as “Vanity” is a huge, winding snake, as large as a mountain range! It opens its mouth, bottomless, and swallows anyone who strays into it.

Erick: It swallows them whole, then spits out the bones in piles a mountain high!

The students gaze unblinkingly, hearts lodged in their throats.

Erick: The monster known as “Emptiness” is a cunning, deceitful creature. One that no one has ever truly seen…!

Erick: It lurks in the shadows. At night, the noises under the bed, the flash outside the window, the drips in the bathroom—any one of them could be it!

Erick: Sometimes, it's right next to your ear; at others, it’s far, far away.

Erick: It stalks grown-ups, not with a gaping jaw but with claws as sharp as potato wedges…

Erick: It silently approaches those drowning in sadness, regret, and despair. When they cover their faces, too overwhelmed to be wary, it extends its bloodied claws…

Erick: Shwoop!

The students shudder in unison.

Erick: To finish off those poor souls!

Erick: In my view, these are the largest and most deadly of critters.

Erick: Of course, I've never met these terrible beasts. Harald says I'm not tall enough yet. But one day, one day, I will.

Erick: I'll knock them down and beat them so hard they can't even stand up straight!

The students' eyes sparkle with admiration, and they quickly break into applause.

Even her opponents, Sancho and Eifer, can't help but get lost in thought.

Golden Key Sancho: …

Effie: …

The instructor sighs. This student will be a bone to chew for sure.

Instructor: Erick, a fitting critter ought to be…

The ring of the school bell cuts her off. Class is dismissed.

The students swarm, flocking towards Erick.

Instructor: Erick, come to my office later.

In the bustling crowd, Erick raises her hand and waves.

Erick: Yes, ma'am!

...

Students' hostel

The night casts its shadows on Erick's youthful cheeks. She breathes softly.

She lies on her bed, underneath which sits "The History of Potions." She twirls her pen in her hand.

After a moment, she stops, buries her head in the paper before her, and begins to write.

Erick: "Dear Harald—"

Erick: "This is my first winter at the SPDM."

Erick: "I've met many new sailors here, each boasting their own impressive tricks."

Erick: "One can make saplings sprout out of stones; another can fly with the wind; there's even one who can foresee test questions!"

Erick: "My fleet has grown much larger, and there are many places here that I can't wait to explore."

Erick: "I will unearth all the treasures I can here, hide them in my drawer, and give some of them to you when you come to pick me up."

She looks up, glancing at the book on the desk, her brows furrowed.

Erick: "But the instructors here are mean. They're always frowning, and they like locking students up in the guardhouse."

Erick: "Today, I spoke of the monsters 'Vanity' and 'Emptiness' in class."

Erick: "The instructor called me to the office and said, 'Those are not considered monsters.' — Can you believe it!?"

Erick: "Then she rambled on about the history of critter surveys and made me memorize it all."

Erick: "In terms of boredom, these instructors are all the same!"

Erick: "Of course, my sailor crewmates support me. They said those were the scariest monsters they'd ever heard of, a hundred times more dangerous than anything in the 'Critter Dictionary!' When I walked out of the office, wow—"

Erick: "They surrounded me, chanting 'Erick', 'Erick', 'Erick'! I'd never seen such a large and enthusiastic crew!"

Erick: "I talked to them from school dismissal till evening. By the end of it, I could hardly feel my tongue!"

Erick: "...But I really miss you, Harald."

She stretches out her hand and rubs her eye.

Erick: "When I walked out of the office, for a brief moment, I was expecting to see you standing by the door. Once I'm done with this adventure, be sure to come pick me up in old John's beat-up car."

The sound of footsteps echoes from under the door.

???: Pfft, pfft!

Erick: Oh, right on time...

Erick: "Tonight's duel challengers are here; I have to go.
"Please say hi to old John and his beat-up car for me."

Erick: "—Your brave and fearless Erick."

She folds the letter, slipping it into an envelope.

Then puts it carefully under her pillow, like a treasure.

George the Oak

Erick: Huff, huff, huff...

Erick pants, hands on the ground, beads of sweat dripping from her golden hair and onto her forehead.

Sancho and Eifer are standing upright, unflinching.

Golden Key Sancho: I thought you were something special... Can't even perform a decent Arcane Skill! Your test scores must be terrible.

Effie: ...Go back to sleep, dueling her is pointless, she's no chance of beating us.

Erick: Not true! If I could take off this arm ring, you two would be running scared!

Golden Key Sancho: Yeah, right, you people always have excuses –– stomach ache, hungry, rainy weather...

Golden Key Sancho: Always concocting a reason for your failures, then making another grand promise before the end of the week!

Effie: It's like running in circles. More pointless than playing catch with a ball...

Footsteps and dim lights approach from the dark road yonder.

???: Hey, you shouldn't be out here. What are you doing!?

Golden Key Sancho: !!!

Golden Key Sancho: Oh no, it's the school disciplinary witch... Run!

But by now, the figure is standing right in front of them. She grabs Eifer and Sancho by their collars.

Matilda: Hah! As the SPDM's disciplinary assistant, leaving without permission—

Matilda: Oh, ow!

Sancho bites the witch's left arm, giving him a moment to escape her grasp.

The "Great" Storyteller: Erick lunges at her other arm...

The witch shakes her arm, releasing Eifer, and then—

Matilda: Hmph! Caught you!
You know it's past curfew...

Erick is pinned to the ground, as if weighed down by a pile of stones.

Erick: Now's your chance. Run, you idiots!

The two snap out of it and run into the darkness.

The "Great" Storyteller: They look back, catching a glimpse of our hero's brave resistance.

The "Great" Storyteller: Until their vision is obscured by the night's mist...

It didn't take long for punishment to arrive.

The corridor is empty and silent. Having been punished, Erick stands alone by the classroom door. Her stomach growls.

She glances at her shoes, idly picks her nose, and stares out the window at the dimming twilight. The orange afterglow has reached her knees.

There's a sudden rustling sound from around the corner.

Erick: A jarl never ever gets scared! Come out now! I mean— you'd better show yourself, or else...

From the corner of the hallway, two little heads pop out like rabbits.

Golden Key Sancho: Are you okay?

Erick's bravely puffed chest finally deflates.

Golden Key Sancho: I snuck you some fried cod... You must be starving.

She grabs the offered meal, devouring it like a bear starved through the winter.

Effie: ...Why did you help us?

Erick: (Munching) Because I can't let my future crew fall into another's hands. It was nothing, really. Being a jarl means more than just giving orders; you have to take on responsibility too.

Erick: Even the most powerful of jarls will eventually fall from grace if they avoid their personal responsibilities and simply order others around.

Golden Key Sancho & Effie: ...Wow!

Erick: I heard that in ancient times, there was a king who ruled over the biggest forest in the world...

Listening intently, Sancho and Eifer gradually lower themselves to the floor until they are fully seated, utterly mesmerized by her vivid storytelling.

From the fading rays of the twilight sun to the silvery glow of moonlight, night gracefully arrives.

Their eyes glow brightly. They swallow hard, absorbing the tales of greatness, wonder, and the incredible.

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Adventures

AGD-03

The Adventures

Letter: "Dear Harald—"

Letter: "Grown-ups often say that torches will extinguish, great trees will wither, and even the endless feasts will eventually end in a great mess."

Letter: "'Heroes too will have their curtain call,' they say earnestly, solemnly, unwilling to move even for the remote control that they're sitting on."

Letter: "Grown-ups act like they know everything, issuing commands like they're kings and queens. But what do they know, really?"

Letter: "Maybe they've only sneaked a peek at the door to glory and pride."

Letter: "They say, 'don't climb too high.'"

Matilda: Get down from that tree right now, you rascals. Or else... I'll make you fall!

Erick: We're not coming down until we catch that Huma bird! I'm sure it'll appear at dusk.

Golden Key Sancho: It's said that if you feed them toenails and smelly boots for three days, they'll grant you a wish. I'll make them eat all the test papers so we won't have any more exams!

Effie: I—I want it to find the book the instructor threw away.

Matilda: Damn, you little troublemakers. I'm coming up!

Erick: No, no, don't! This tree can't take anymore— Ah—!

Golden Key Sancho & Effie: Ahh—!

Letter: "They say, 'don't think too much.'"

Erick: ...Will the ghost really come? I'm getting sleepy.

Effie: It will, I'm sure of it! They say that the ghost of that missing student appears here on the night of every full moon...

Golden Key Sancho: And if we find him, he'll reveal the exam questions for next week!

Erick: Okay, well, I'm going to lay down and sleep for a bit until he—

Golden Key Sancho: (Patter, patter) Look!
The ghost is here.

Matilda: The moon is just perfect tonight...♫
Hum-dee-dum, now to take out my orbuculum.

Matilda: Huh? Who's there!

Erick: Ahh—!
Run!

Letter: "They say, 'don't run too fast.'"

Instructor: In this lesson, you will learn how to deal with a glavakus.
Now, I will release a domestically bred...

Erick: Ahhhh— My cloak!
Sailors, stop it!

Glawackus: Roaaar!

Golden Key Sancho: Jarl, quick! Stop now—!

Effie: It follows loud, fast-moving things—!

Erick: I can't—hear—you!

Letter: "Don't climb too high, don't think too much, don't run too fast, don't be too selfish, don't wander too far, don't go... on adventures!"

Letter: "If we listened to these grown-ups, all those amazing treasures, great feats, and countless heroic tales would end up like the remote control under their butts: lost in the couch forever!"

Letter: "So, my dear Harald—I've gathered a crew of SPDM students with extraordinary abilities to lead a rebellion against all these boring grown-ups."

Letter: "They are loyal and dedicated to me."
"They have remained unflinching; even in the face of the nasty witch."

Golden Key Sancho: I swear, it was me who ate the fish and chips. I ate it all on my own!

Matilda: ...

Effie: (Patter, patter) Jarl, the corner of your mouth...

Erick: Oh!

Letter: "They possess the wisdom of Mimir and the agility of Thor."
"Even the craftiest of witches are helpless against them."

Matilda: Hey, what's that bulging in your pocket?

Erick: It's, uh, it's...

Effie: —It's the stinky, chewy chunk I gave her!

Effie: You wouldn't want to fish it out with your hand. It'll make you so sick that you won't be able to eat the whole night long!

Matilda: Sniff, sniff...

Letter: "Even in the most critical moments—"

Golden Key Sancho: Hey—hey! Isn't that Miss Sonetto?

Matilda: Hmm? What?! P-Perhaps she needs the help of an outstanding disciplinary assistant!

Matilda: I-I'll be right back!

Letter: My crew and I always find a way out.

Erick: "I have to say, my heart is bursting with excitement!"

Erick: "My dear Harald, I can't wait to show you everything I've achieved here."

Erick: "Also, how is my crew at Stillwater Lake doing? Did Dumb Howard take over the park? Did Old John find the note I stuck on the bumper of his car? Ha-ha-ha, he must have been furious..."

Erick: "Also, I got the chewing gum you sent. My crew absolutely loves it."

Erick: "Also, how come your handwriting looks so much neater? Is Aunt Sigrid from next door writing your letters for you?"

Erick: "Hah, she's got you all figured out!"

Erick: "Anyway, I hope everything is well with you."

Erick: "Well, I'm off to sleep! This 'Introduction to Alchemy' book is as heavy as a rock and gives me a headache."

Erick: "—Missing you, Erick."

TO BE CONTINUED...

The End of a Sweet Dream

AGD-04

The End of a Sweet Dream

"The children, soaring over sleepy houses and the sparkling sea, finally reach the dreamy island."

"The tide loves them so much it rolls itself into a blanket to welcome them."

"The fairies gather around, plucking waves and stars to crown them."

"The joyous children climb the highest cliffs above the sea."

"But don't get too comfortable, and don't let your guard down."

"Children. When dusk falls upon the island, you'll know it's coming."

Curfew holds no sway over these nimble little feet.

Three shadows tiptoe by the silent lakeshore. Even the smallest cough would shatter the stillness in the air.

But the silence can only last so long, and despite their best efforts to keep quiet, a voice slips out.

Golden Key Sancho: Say, do you think that critter will really take us as its masters?

Golden Key Sancho: Strange... It dug a hole there under its butt, put the can of food inside, then spat on it.

Golden Key Sancho: Boss, maybe we should try something else...

Effie: Sancho, how does your knowledge of critters suck so much? The instructor literally explained this morning that glavakus use their spit to distinguish food from trash.

Erick: Right, right. The instructors may be boring, but they do spout some wisdom.

Erick: One day, this big boy will willingly serve us and be our obedient mount!

Erick: Also, there's a saying. How does it go? “When God locks the door, he leaves a window open through which we may slip out.”

Effie: Uh, Jarl, I don’t think that’s—

Golden Key Sancho: Hey, duck down! Duck down! The witch is coming again!

Effie: Don't step on my foot! Gah! I literally just polished these shoes tonight!

Erick: Shush! She's coming!

Their hands meet their faces as they huddle together.

The witch hurries past. She pauses at a critter cage on the other side of the room.

Matilda: "Oh... glavakus Number 15, why do you have diarrhea again?! I've been feeding you exactly according to the 'Critter Feeding Manual'..."

Matilda: Someone else must be feeding you...

Glawackus: *Brrrr*...

The poor creature, unable to speak, curls up in distress.

Dejected, the three unreliable "masters" sneak away.

As the night deepens, they return to the dormitory.

Effie: Ugh, I have to go to class all sweaty again tomorrow...

Golden Key Sancho: Ha-ha-ha, you smell just like that critter! Maybe it'll even take you as its leader.

Eifer's face turns red. She pinches his arm hard.

Effie: Hmph! I'll put a curse on you to be thrown out of school tonight! Not even the instructors can protect you then!

Effie: You’ll be like a soap bubble floating in the sewer!

Golden Key Sancho: Hey, Eifer, don't...

Sancho suddenly turns solemn. He shakes his head, signaling her to stop.

Golden Key Sancho: ...Boss’s family.

The jarl's smile fades, and worry fills her eyes.

Eifer immediately feels guilty.

Effie: Sorry, Erick, I was just saying.

Effie: Your dad and grandpa must be—

Erick: Duck! Hide behind the wall!

Erick clasps her hands over their mouths, instantly muffling their voices.

A suspicious looking figure lurks by a red postbox nearby.

Erick: Looks like someone's up to no good with our mailbox...

Golden Key Sancho: Ewww... Boss, why does your hand smell weird?

Erick: Oh, sorry, I patted the glavakus's butt earlier.

She quickly lowers her hand, shaking it as if doing so could rid the stink.

Effie: Ginger hair, checkered headband... hey, isn't that the distinguished alumna, Sonetto?!

Effie: Oh... her hair is so pretty! Much prettier than my sister's. When I graduate, I want to dye mine the color of the leaves in autumn.

Golden Key Sancho: Isn't she the one who was top of the class in Potion Studies, Basic Arcanism, and Critter Training a few years ago?! Move your head, I want to see too!

Erick: Nothing to fuss over, crew. She may be great, but she's just one of my former opponents. For a bard, she's—

Effie: Strange, is she mailing something? But these aren't the non-student mailboxes...

Golden Key Sancho: Look, she's stuffing a letter in there. But that's... that's...!

Erick: !!!

Having completed the task, the Sonetto hurries away.

As silence returns under the night sky, Erick dashes to her mailbox, pulling out the letter.

...

"To Erick..." The sender had falsely signed "...Harald" at the bottom.

Golden Key Sancho: Boss, why did you run so fast... Oh, is this a gift from Sonetto?! I thought everyone's mail was delivered by the postman during the day...

Golden Key Sancho: Hey, Boss...?

Sonetto: Don't worry, during the term, Harald will still... send you letters every month. The school postman is very punctual.

Sonetto: You can write to him too; your communication will be unhindered...

Vertin: We promised him that we would ensure your safety at school.

Vertin: He trusts you can handle this. I'm certain you will.

...

"You can trust these two, they're good people. —Yours forever, Harald."

Erick: Have they been lying?

Erick: Besides the first, all the letters were...

Erick: If it's all a lie, then what's the point of all this?

Erick: The treasure, territories, crew... what's the point of my ambitions?

Golden Key Sancho: Hey, Boss?

Golden Key Sancho: ...Ever since you got that letter yesterday, you've been acting a bit strange.

Effie: Erick... Erick!

Erick: Oh... sorry, what were you saying?

Effie: What's wrong?

Erick: N-Nothing, just leave me be.

Her gaze becomes vacant again, as if all this weren't real.

Steady footsteps approach from a distance.

The students watch the advancing figure, lips firmly sealed.

Instructor: Erick, there is a suspicion that you snuck off to the critter shed by the lake yesterday and fed the critters there. As I'm sure you're aware, this is against the school rules.

Instructor: As of right now, there's no second witness to prove it was you. But, if it was you...

Eifer stands up.

Effie: Sh-She was with us the whole time yesterday, I can testify!

Golden Key Sancho: I can too!

Erick: It was me.

Erick stands up, arms dropping to her sides...

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Fake Story

AGD-05

A Fake Story

Instructor: We accepted you as per the 'SPDM Listen-in Student Regulations,' giving you the opportunity to study alongside top scoring students.

Her eyes are as sharp as an eagle's.

Instructor: Otherwise, under the existing school rules, a student your age would be turned away.

Instructor: A lack of formal Arcanist education is only one factor...

Instructor: After all, instilling technical and theoretical knowledge is of no difficulty to us.

Instructor: But noble character, respect for order, and the pursuit of dedicating oneself to the peace of mankind—these require an extensive educational period for our students to fully understand.

Instructor: I believe the St. Pavlov Foundation put much thought into the decision that has allowed you to stand here.

Instructor: You should feel honored.

Erick: ...

Instructor: Two distinguished graduates vouched for you and signed the 'Guardian Responsibility Treaty.'

Instructor: They didn't have to do this. It means that any rule violation on your part will directly impact their personal reputation.

Instructor: So... think carefully about every word you're about to say. You're not just defending yourself...

Erick: "Don't be selfish," "Think of others"... You grown-ups just love to bring others into everything; shift responsibility for everyone else onto our shoulders! I don't plan on defending anyone.

Erick: ...I'm willing to accept all the consequences.

Erick grabs the massive stone table. It begins to tremble, as if caught in an earthquake.

Instructor: What are you doing?! Put the table down now!

Erick: ...I need to talk to Vertin.

Instructor: You took off the arm ring—?

Instructor: But they had already—

She glances at the girl's arm. The band mark is coiling around it like a red python.

"Bang!"

She hurls the stone table into the corner, and it shatters with a deafening crash.

Erick: I need to ask her something important... I don't want to hurt you.

Instructor: No, Erick... I'm afraid you need to calm down first.

Instructor: Security!

"Bang! Bang! Bang!"

One by one, the staff members are hurled out of the office.

Guard I: Good heavens... This is far beyond our regular dealings. She's akin to a little lion!

Guard II: We need to bring out the restraining equipment... Tell the logistics department to open the storage room!

Erick: I'm sorry... I really don't want to hurt you.

Erick: Please, instructor, I just want to talk to her. After that... I'll accept any punishment.

Instructor: ...

Meanwhile, rapid footsteps sound from afar.

Before any message is relayed, two Foundation staff members arrive. It's as if they had foreseen the event.

Foundation Staff: Excuse me, instructor. You can leave now.

Foundation Staff: We'll take it from here.

Instructor: It appears you anticipated correctly.

Instructor: Well, there's not much more I can do.

She heaves a sigh and leaves.

Erick: ...

The corridor is silent again. All the students have returned to their dormitories.

Erick waits in her chair, trying to make out the muffled conversation taking place outside the office. A tall hat appears in the door frame.

Vertin: We can talk now.

Erick: Phew... Thank you for coming. Now I don't have to climb over the wall to find you.

Vertin: Erick, this isn't what you promised us.

Erick: No, no, you need to answer me first.

She cuts her off with the sharpness of a knife.

Erick: Are you a smooth-talking liar like all the other grown-ups? Don't lie to me; I can see into your eyes...

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I don't think so.

Erick: Good. Then please tell me—

She takes a deep breath before speaking.

Erick: What happened outside? Harald and the others... what really happened?

A familiar question, brought up yet again.

But times have changed, and nothing is as it once was.

What's important is that a promise was made. And the truth needs to remain hidden now more than ever.

Harald sits, carving a rough piece of wood with a hand knife.

Despite his burly arms, his hands are incredibly gentle. The blade caresses the wood, carefully shaving off the excess.

Only he knows that this body is fast losing its strength.

Harald: Okay... now her little wooden sword has a home to return to.

He extends a bloodied hand, presenting a wooden sheath and a letter.

Vertin: What's this?

Harald: Some things I must say.

In the distance, rugged figures have begun gathering.

Manus Monster I: *roars*

Manus Monster II: *roars*

They are like a tide, like a swarm of bees.

Harald: One, two, three...

He starts counting, but quickly gives up, shaking his head. Their number is far beyond that of the fingers on both hands.

He shifts his gaze back.

Harald: You must do one last thing for me.

Harald: Please... don't tell my dear child the truth about all this.

His hand clutches the small wooden sheath, not yet ready to let it go.

Vertin: I can't stop this.

Harald: No, you must.

This is not a plea.

In a flash, the bloodied tip of his knife is at Vertin's throat.

Harald: I don't want to hurt you.

Vertin: You can't stop her from growing up.

Harald: ...Child, trust me.

Harald: When you reach my age, you'll understand that "growing up" is just a nice way of saying that people have to change—That we are forced to move forward.

Harald: She will make those steps on her own; I believe that more than anyone. But before that...

Harald: Before that, I want her to wander a bit longer, see the sights, go where she pleases.

Harald: To experience all that's bitter, sour, foul-smelling. To try everything with an open mind.

Harald: In the end, she'll come to understand on her own.

Harald: ...Promise me that you'll find a good place for her.

Vertin: Mm-hmm.

Harald: You promise?

He retracts the knife from her neck and pulls off his bloodstained beast-cloak, revealing his arm ring. He removes it.

His hand trembles as he hands it over.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I promise.

Vertin: I promise, what's happening outside is an anomaly that you can't yet understand. Everyone has been afflicted with a serious illness.

Vertin: But we will eventually find a way to resolve this disaster.

Erick finally deflates her puffed chest.

Erick: ...A serious illness?

Erick: But what about those letters? There wasn't a word about that in any of them.

Erick: Those replies... and the gifts... no, it doesn't make sense.

She recalls what she saw last night.

Erick: You're not telling the truth... What else are you hiding from me? You never tell the truth, always covering one hole with another—

Her vision begins to blur.

Something warm trickles from her nose. It smells ... metallic.

Erick: Is this... blood?

She gives a puzzled look at the drops of dark red liquid on her palm.

...

Vertin: Erick!

TO BE CONTINUED...

The Song of Innocence

AGD-06

The Song of Innocence

Laplace Rehabilitation Center

Mesmer Jr.: She's in a deep sleep. Unlike adults, who often relive traumatic memories during this time, children face the danger of never waking up from their dreams at all.

Vertin: Do we have a way to wake her up?

Mesmer Jr.: Was I not clear enough? This is a "condition," not an ordinary state of sleep. Forcibly waking her could cause serious brain trauma.

Mesmer Jr.: Aside from letting her little brain wake up on its own, there is no other solution.

Mesmer Jr.: ...Such an out of control Arcanist ought to be subject to more stringent and regular checks.

Mesmer Jr.: The LSCC's research on her grandfather's arm ring is still in the exploratory phase. It won't be of immediate help to her.

Mesmer Jr.: Moreover, the death records here show that her mother was hospitalized for the same reason.

Mesmer Jr.: This is the "gift" that accompanies their family's Arcanism, a rare kind of hereditary illness.

Mesmer Jr.: Fortunately, though, we have a sample right here with us now. This should prove useful in treating Arcanist illnesses.

Mesmer Jr.: You have indeed made a good deal with her grandfather, Vertin.

She presses a needle into Erick's wrist, and slowly releases the liquid within.

Mesmer Jr.: This is 5 milliliters of Mandragora extract, a hemostatic and neural blocker. It will slow the worsening of her condition to maintain her vital signs for about 2–3 days, but it's far greater than the normal dose.

Mesmer Jr.: Even a carbuncle nearly 7 feet tall would be knocked unconscious by this. It's commonly used in the black market for live critter dissection.

Vertin: But aren't we supposed to be finding a way to wake her up?

Mesmer Jr.: Aside from the coma, she has other, more lethal issues.

Mesmer Jr.: According to the blood dilution analysis report, her body is abnormally "expending" blood. Her veins are filled with blood-sucking parasites.

Mesmer Jr.: The most conservative treatment is to first calm these "parasites."

Mesmer Jr.: As I'm sure you know, this is our last sample.

She returns the empty vial to the shelf.

Mesmer Jr.: I'll come back in 4 hours.

The medication quickly takes effect. Her breathing becomes lighter.

Outside, dark clouds gather. They are building up to a downpour.

...

The direct light is dazzling. Erick rubs her eyes. Her brain is on the verge of waking, but the sleepiness is unstoppable.

Erick: @#&*¥@...

As she mutters incomprehensibly in her sleep, the softness of her blanket pulls her deeper into her dreams.

Her body instinctively rolls away from the light—

"Thud!"

Erick: Ouch! That hurts...

Erick: Oww, my head! It's going to swell up as big as a bar of soap.

Erick: Huh? Wait, this is...!

Erick: My room?!

The storybook lies open there on the floor.

The carpet is sticky with chewing gum, smelly socks crumpled on the ground. All the familiar messiness—

Harald: My little sleepyhead, has winter finally passed?

Erick: Harald?! Is this real?! Wait, I'll pull a hair to see if I'm dreaming...

Erick: Ouch... Ow! That really hurts!

Harald: Go wash your face quickly, and grab your helmet and weapons. Your dad's already gone to pick up your little sailors.

Erick: But, but why...

Harald: Oh, have you forgotten? Today is the "Victory Party" I told you about. I'm so impressed that you've completed such a perilous journey. What a feat! I'm proud of you, child.

Erick: Right... that sounds familiar...

Harald: Looks like that fall really did a number on your head... We'll wait for you downstairs, child.

Harald: Remember to tidy up your room a bit.

Erick: Okay, okay! You're starting to sound like nagging Old John!

She scratches her messy hair, opens the wardrobe, and starts rummaging around...

Erick: But when did I get home...? I don't remember a thing.

Erick: Where was I before—

Little Sailors: Welcome home, Erick!

Erick: Oh! Sailors, you scared me!

The children swarm around her, holding her hands, crowding her onto a throne draped with bearskin.

Snotty Buck: Erick, I heard you went to a place full of witches!

Jason "the Slob": They could go anywhere unimpeded and could even predict exam questions! And they had monsters that could eat a tire whole in one bite.

Little Sailors: Is it true?! Is it true?!

Erick: Calm down, sailors; it wasn't as scary as that. Though it was certainly perilous, the witches there were actually quite reasonable...

Erick: And those monsters, wow, you have to see them to believe it. I can't even begin to describe how scary they looked.

Little Sailors: Tell us, tell us!

Erick: So, listen up, that place...

A grand story begins anew, the children gasp in horror yet are unable to pull themselves away. They crane their necks like a little herd of giraffes.

Old John clatters in the kitchen, occasionally glancing at his daughter before going back to stirring his pot of thick soup.

Erick: There, I had two of the greatest sailors. They were...

Erick: They were...

The children continue to stare at her.

Erick: Sorry, it's strange... I can't remember a thing.

As if a stone is suddenly lodged in her throat, she can no longer continue the story.

???: Hey, Erick. Hey!

A voice seems to push through a thin membrane.

Erick: Did you guys... hear something?

Jason "the Slob": Nope, I didn't hear anything.

Snotty Buck: Heh-heh, I heard it! Jason, you bad boy, you ripped a stealthy one!

Jason "the Slob": Y-You're talking nonsense!

They scrap it out, first Jason on top of Buck, then Buck targeting Jason's ticklish spot.

They grab their desired pillows to start a pillow fight on the sofa.

The living room becomes a chaotic playground, with children cheering and laughing uproariously.

???: Pfft, pfft!

???: Shh, don't bring "it" over here... be quiet, you idiot.

Two tiny figures press against the window, whispering.

But apart from Erick, no one else seems to notice them. She approaches the window and peers out.

Erick: You two idiots, what are you doing standing there at my doorstep? Come in, all my friends are welcome!

???: ...But w-we can't go in, Erick.

???: "It" is coming...

???: When "it" arrives, it takes away all joy. "It" will take away the candy and amusement parks, the fun of running away, and your prized little wooden sword.

???: "It" will eat your heart, so you'll never feel excitement again. Your feet will feel like they're chained, and your head will feel like it's carrying a hundred gold pieces, too heavy to lift again.

???: Eventually, you'll start forgetting, forgetting the great stories and the treasures at your fingertips.

???: We don't want that; we can't let "it" in.

Erick: Don't worry, guys, I'll knock "it" down before it can even take a breath!

???: But it's our turn to protect you now, Jarl!

???: Shh, shh! "It" is coming, run!

The figures outside the window flee fast.

She quickly opens the window.

Erick: ...Strange, what's going on?

The setting sun casts its rays, hitting her face and the green lawn outside. The sprinkler is hissing.

But there's no one there.

Harald: ...This is a frightening monster, child.

Harald: I mean... yes, I do know of it.

Erick: What kind of monster is it? I didn't even see what it looks like...

Harald: Do you remember the museum ticket seller, the lady who always picked you up?

Erick: Ms. Sigrid? Oh, her face was long and sour, her voice croaky like an old crow. If she caught you doing something she didn't like, you were in for a serious paddling.

Erick: The worst part was having to listen to her endless lectures afterward. "Children should behave themselves." "When I was your age..." Blah, blah, blah. I'd rather walk the plank!

Harald: Do you remember the day you climbed the "World Tree" and the carvings you found at the top?

Erick: *"The Eagle Feeder tops them all."*

Erick: *"The next kid to read these words will become the new master of the World Tree."*

Harald: It was Ms. Sigrid who carved those words.

Harald: When she was your age, she ran faster and jumped further than any boy in the village. But, none of the boys wanted to admit that a girl could best them.

Harald: So, one day, they dared her to climb the World Tree, the tallest tree in the village. If she failed, then she would have to say they had been letting her win all along.

Harald: We all know what happened next.

He sighs deeply, spreading his hands.

Harald: But, adults always think a girl running fast or getting sun-tanned... is not a good thing.

Harald: So, one day, the Eagle Feeder met this monster. At first, they were evenly matched, palm against claw, stubbornness against obstinacy.

Harald: But eventually, she wore out.

Harald: Her heart was torn to shreds by that monster, but no one ever saw her shed a tear.

Harald: —And then she became Ms. Sigrid, the gloomy ticket seller who's always telling off kids.

Erick, sitting on the bed's edge, lowers her head uneasily.

Erick: ...I'm so sorry for what I said about her. She was a courageous hero. That monster... must have been truly scary...

Harald: Yes. It has no name, and no one has ever seen it with their own eyes. You must be careful.

Erick: But now, it's relentlessly pursuing my two sailors... They led the monster away to protect me.

Harald: They are brave too.

Erick: But what should I do? what should I do? Harald, can you help me?

She looks up eagerly, her eyes wide with hope.

Harald: I'm afraid not, child... My hands are too big, and the monster too small; my footsteps are too heavy, and its too light.

Harald: Only a child could defeat it, and only a child could be defeated by it.

Erick: But what if I lose to it? If I become like Ms. Sigrid... will you still love me the same?

Harald: No matter what you become.

He holds the child's arms until she stops trembling and raises her head.

It felt like she was gazing into his eyes a thousand, ten thousand times over.

Harald: I'll be waiting for you.

Her palms no longer tremble, her steps grow lighter.

She runs down the hallway.

Runs down the stairs.

Runs through the bustling living room.

Jason "the Slob": Erick, where are you going? Are you leaving the party?

Snotty Buck: You can't go, we've been waiting ages for you. Look, we even brought a popcorn machine from the shop!

Little Sailors: We want to hear your stories about your grand adventure, about the treasures you brought back!

Erick: Sorry...

Erick: I miss you all and those good old days of adventuring...

Erick: But I've made a promise to two other sailors you don't know. I can't abandon them...

Erick: Sailors, I'll come back for you, but not now.

Erick: Jason, sorry... I'll return your homework later. You can blame it on me.

Jason "the Slob": ...Don't worry, boss. My behind is battle-hardened. Even if the teacher comes with a branding iron, I won't utter a sound!

Erick: And Buck, if Nasty Abel still bothers you while I'm gone... tell him to stop acting smug; Jarl Erick will settle the score.

Erick: If he wants more trouble, take Jason's hellhound "Garm" over there.

Erick: Remember, it only eats sturgeon fish that have been left out for three days and three nights.

Snotty Buck: Thank you…

The children watch her, like a farewell choir.

She grabs the doorknob, feeling the cold metal in her palm.

Suddenly, a hand reaches out to stop her.

Erick: Old John… don't block the way, this isn't—

—He wraps both hands around her shoulders.

He ruffles her golden hair. His embrace makes it hard for her to breathe.

But she doesn't resist, she just allows him to hold her tightly, so tightly.

Eventually, he lets go.

Erick: I have to go.

She turns the doorknob.

The dawn light spills through the gaps in the trees, illuminating her in patterns.

Erick: Goodbye, Dad.

TO BE CONTINUED…

Awakening Hours

AGD-07

The Waking Moment

Erick: …

Sonetto: Erick?!

Mesmer Jr.: 6 minutes and 37 seconds. Consistent with the awakening trend on the monitoring device.

She jots down several notes in the medical record book.

Mesmer Jr.: Lie back down and don't move. I'll get the medicine.

They are left alone in the hospital room.

…

Sonetto: You've been unconscious for days… They thought you would never wake up.

Erick: Cough, cough… I was planning to visit Valhalla.

Erick: But Harald and those stinky old lice-ridden men grabbed my ears and said it wasn't my time yet.

Erick: That's a bit—

Sonetto lays her hand on Erick's.

Sonetto: …Erick, I'm sorry.

Sonetto: Those letters… they weren't actually written by Harald—

She freezes, then gently shakes her head.

Erick: I understand.

Erick: Thank you for being honest, and for all you've done for me.

There is no longer doubt in her eyes.

Erick: How are those grown-ups I injured? I... didn't mean to toss them so hard.

Erick: They won't let me go back, will they?

Sonetto: Well...

Sonetto: The SPDM's management committee has submitted your transfer application...

???: **What—?!**

The bed frame begins to shake violently.

Two dusty little heads pop out from under the bed.

Erick: Hey, what are you two doing here?

Sonetto: I asked the instructor to bring them here. I thought it might help your condition...

But no one is paying any attention to her response.

Golden Key Sancho: Boss, you can't drop out!

Golden Key Sancho: I—I, I can bring out my precious Sharpodonty collection! The book I read said that staff and instructors always fall for that...

Erick: ...Sancho, don't.

Erick: Your critter has been waiting in Ms. NewBabel's cage for so long...

Erick: Besides—(cough, cough...)

She hunches over, covering her mouth as if choking on thick smoke.

Sancho opens his mouth to speak, but he can't say a word.

Her coughing... is like a small wooden hammer pounding on their hearts.

Effie: Really... there's no hope left?

Sonetto: Sorry...

Effie: ...If you leave, I'll never talk to anyone else ever again.

Effie: (Sob...) I thought I finally found a real friend... but it turns out all this effort was for nothing.

Effie: I knew it would end like this, yet I still planned so much with you...

Effie: "People delude themselves into passion in life, painting a portrait of themselves; but in the end, they are left with nothing but the portrait."

Effie: They were right... (Sob)

She lowers her head, her shoulders shaking. She wipes the tears and snot from her face.

Golden Key Sancho: Don't be like this, Eifer... The boss is hurting too.

Effie: (Sob...) No, she isn't; if you ask me, we've all been deceived.

Effie: What about the mountains of treasures? The monsters called "Emptiness" and "Vanity"? There's no such thing anywhere in the world.

Effie: If there were, you would have taken us to see it for ourselves!

Erick: ...

Effie: You're so reckless, always getting us into trouble. Because of you, my semester badge got revoked.

Effie: You don't actually have a ship or any of those thrilling adventures. You just have a silly little wooden sword!

Effie: (Sob...) And what can you command with it? What can you cut with it?

She covers her eyes with her arms, but the tears keep falling and the snot keeps dripping.

"Drip, drip—"

Effie: I knew it all, everything—

Effie: Even so, we still followed you around.

Effie: But now, you don't care about us anymore (sob sob sob...)

Golden Key Sancho: The boss hasn't abandoned us—

She pushes away the tissue presented in Sancho's hand.
She doesn't even glimpse at Erick.

She runs off like a child soaked by the rain.

Golden Key Sancho: Hey, hey, Eifer—!

Erick: Sorry...

Golden Key Sancho: It's okay, boss... It's not your fault.

A nurse pushes in a medicine cart, followed by a familiar hat.

Golden Key Sancho: Look... I have to go too.

Golden Key Sancho: Get well soon, boss.

Erick: (Cough, cough, cough)

Erick: Wait...!

He too leaves.

...

Mesmer Jr.: Put out your hand.

Mesmer Jr.: Take a deep breath.

Mesmer Jr.: There will be momentary pain in your wrist, but after 1 minute and 28 seconds, your arm will be completely numb.

TO BE CONTINUED...

A Leap Into the Future

AGD-08

A Leap Into the Future

"Pirates flee in terror. Children hold conches filled with honey and milk."

"They fall asleep in groups on the damp deck."

"But on the other side, the adults weep, and the light of the lamp by the bed shines into their dreams."

"So when dawn comes, the first child returns home."

Letter: Harald... this is my last day at the SPDM.

Letter: ~~Harald... this is my last day at the SPDM.~~

Letter: Harald, I had a good time here...

Letter: ~~Harald, I had a good time here...~~

Letter: Harald... If you can't see these letters, then what's the point of me writing them?

Erick: ...

She leans back in her chair and stares at the ceiling with a vacant gaze.

Neither in pain nor weary, yet heavy in every way.

What is that? What is that...?

???: Pfft, pfft!

Erick: Huh?!

A head pops into view.

Golden Key Sancho: Hehe~ surprise attack successful!

Erick: San...cho? What are you doing here? Haven't you got Critter Training Class today?

Golden Key Sancho: Forget about class.
It's been boring since you stopped attending.

Golden Key Sancho: I thought I'd come to see you off, boss.

Golden Key Sancho: I had a hard time finding your dorm. With all those winding corridors, I almost got lost.

Golden Key Sancho: Wow, your room is so much bigger than mine. I'm jealous.

He looks around. The once scattered books are now neatly piled in the corner.

All that mess, those cherished things, are now packed into boxes.

It's as if they were never there.

And suddenly, the weight of reality makes his heart tremble.

Golden Key Sancho: I didn't know... you packed up so quickly.

Golden Key Sancho: You're... leaving already?

???: ......!

The feet behind the door have become restless.

Effie: ...

Golden Key Sancho: Hey! Eifer, didn't we agree that I'd go first—?

Effie: We still have a secret plan to carry out!

Effie: You! Deserter with the rolled up bedding!

She points her finger like a judge scoffing at a criminal.

Erick: What?! I didn't run away!

Erick leaps up from her chair.

Effie: A scurrying thief, a traitor who drops his weapon, a stupid... pirate!

Erick: Hey, hey! If you had stopped at the first two, we could still be friends, but that last one...

Erick: We're going to have to part ways, you... crybaby!

Effie: Humph, if you've got the guts, come with us!

Effie: But, I guess you wouldn't dare! You just can't wait to go running back to your grandfather.

Effie: "Waaah—Harald, I miss you so much, waaah, waaah waaah!"

Effie: Let's go, Sancho.

She runs to the door and makes a big funny face.

Erick: Uh—ah! Just you wait!

She tosses aside her chair and charges down the hallway.

She pushes open the door, pushes past the white robes, pushes past the gaze of the children.

Pushes past the curtains that fell of their own accord.

Pushes past the endless persuasion of the adults—

Letter: “Dear Harald,”

Letter: “This is my last day at the SPDM.”

Letter: “I feel more uneasy than ever, as if lost in an endless night.”

Letter: “I'm really scared, terribly so.”

Effie: Shh... the instructor has gone to bed. We need to be quieter.

Golden Key Sancho: Come out, come out, don't be afraid. The boss doesn't bite.

He opens the cage, and the glavakus sniffs his hand, hesitating.

Letter: “I think I met that monster you told me about, but I couldn't defeat it.”

Letter: “Of course, it hasn't defeated me, either.”

Golden Key Sancho: Good job, good boy, that's it. Come meet our boss.

Glawackus: Aroo...?

It looks up innocently.

Golden Key Sancho: Now, lie down, let our boss sit on you.

Glawackus: #&%¥!

It opens its mouth and bites her cape.

Erick: ...

Letter: “But I've recognized its form.”

Letter: “Just as it recognized me—”

Letter: “They say every child has to face some hardship to realize their own form. To end up where they ought to be.”

Letter: “They say every ambitious ship crew eventually runs out of food and sneaks back to the old harbor on a quiet night.”

Letter: “So I guess I've always been scared, scared like a cornered squirrel.”

Letter: “I'm afraid of the endless nights without you, that I’ll lose all my courage and run away.”

Letter: “I'm afraid that the grown-ups are right, and the children are wrong.”

Letter: “That all this is just a child's fantasy.”

Letter: “That heroes and treasures no longer exist in this world.”

Letter: ...

Letter: “But they do exist, Harald.”

Letter: “My little wooden sword was never sharp.”

Letter: “And my ship would be easily overturned by a small wave.”

Letter: “But I'd rather be swallowed by a wave than sit at home on a sofa.”

Letter: “I'd rather perish and be immortalized in the epics of a minstrel than idly daydream of futures that will never come—”

Letter: “I won’t wait for a predetermined fate to take me.”

Letter: “Besides, my sailors look to me for guidance.”

Golden Key Sancho: It—it, lowered its head, boss!!!

Effie: Now's the chance!

Glawackus: ...?

Erick: Now!

Erick: Hehe, looks like the canned food we hid for you worked.

Erick: Come, my ravenous friend.

Erick: Forward, swallow the gold, swallow the test papers, swallow the teaching sticks!

Matilda: Hey! What are you doing? Get off that glavakus!

Golden Key Sancho & Effie: Run!

Letter: “The crew will eventually part ways. The banquet will fall silent.”

Letter: “In the end, everything is in vain.”

Letter: “Nothing will remain.”

Erick: Ha-ha-ha-ha!

The "Great" Storyteller: But I’ll tell you—those who defy make the journey worthwhile.

This story is dedicated to
the daydreamers
and those whose souls are free from the restrictions of their body.

The Three Musketeers

Who Is "Madam Ghost?"

Erick the Fleet-Footed

-THE END-

Visitors, doctors... everyone has gone.

The room sits in perfect silence.

Vertin: Erick, I'm sorry. You know our agreement.

Vertin: Due to this incident, you’ll be transferred to the School of Corrections until they determine you have sufficient self-control and common sense...

The child doesn't resist, emitting a consenting hum.

Vertin: But first, I think...

Vertin: You should know the truth about what's happening outside.

Erick: Mm-hmm, I'm ready.

She immediately shakes her head.

Erick: But I want to see it for myself.

She looks out the window, turning her gaze to the stormy sky.

THE END